armory.

Languedoc was close, its castles were wealthy, and the prospect of gain was great. By the middle of 1210, ten thousand Crusaders strong had gathered in Lyons, ready to march south. King Philip II himself begged off, offering as an excuse the need to stay in Paris and keep his defenses against John strong. But among the Crusaders assembled at Lyons was Simon de Montfort, the dispossessed Earl of Leicester. Barred from England, he had found a new cause in Western Francia.

Raymond was stubborn, not stupid. When he heard of the huge force assembled against him, he sent the pope a message of abject repentance, and joined the Crusade himself.

The war that followed lasted twenty years. It was known as the Albigensian Crusade, a name taken from one of the Cathar sects known as Albigenses, but it was fought, wholesale, against all Cathars, all supporters of Cathars, and anyone suspected of Catharism: a vicious and indiscriminate war.

At first, the Crusaders organized under the supreme command of one of the surviving papal legates: Arnold, the Abbot of Cisteaux. He led them southward to the city of Béziers, south of Lyon, across the Hérault river. Béziers was home to both Cathars and orthodox Christians, and the bishop of Béziers ("an excellent man," says William of Tudela) went out to remonstrate with the army. He was told that if the Catholics would "quit the city and leave the heretics behind," they would be spared. But when he returned to Béziers with this message, the citizens refused to desert their homes. "The majority of the townspeople said . . . that the crusaders should not get so much as a pennyworth of their possessions from them," William adds. It was clear, even across a stone wall, that the Crusaders, zealous for the cause of the Church, were not unmindful of the wealth of Languedoc.[11]

This presented the Crusaders with a small problem, and several of the French knights came to the Abbot of Cisteaux asking how they were supposed to tell the Christians and the heretics (*bonos et malos*) apart during a siege. "Kill them all," the Abbot answered. "The Lord knows which ones belong to him."[12]

Caedite eos: Novit enim Dominus qui sunt eius. The sentence, recorded by the scholar-monk Caesarius of Heisterbach in his *Dialogue of Miracles*, may not be exactly what fell from the Abbot's lips, but the sack of Béziers that followed suggests that the order was conveyed. De Cernay tells us that when the city's defenses were breached, "almost all" of the inhabitants were killed, "from the youngest to the oldest." "They killed everyone who fled into the church," William of Tudela writes, "no cross or altar or crucifix could save